



STAKEHOLDER PARTICIPATION AND PROJECT SUCCESS

An Empirical Literature Review

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Introduction

Over the past thirty years, there has been a growing recognition in project management research that the success or failure of a project may be determined by the individuals and groups involved. Project donors, funders, implementing agencies, government regulators, beneficiaries, community members, and any other party whose interests are impacted by project activities or results make up this group of interested parties, also known as stakeholders. In order to include these parties' opinions, resources, and expectations into the project, stakeholder participation refers to their intentional engagement with project activities such as identification, planning, execution, monitoring and evaluation, and decision-making.

Project success, on the other hand, is the extent to which a project achieves its goals. It is usually evaluated based on factors like timely completion, budget adherence, deliverable quality, stakeholder satisfaction, and the sustainability of project benefits after donor or sponsor support ends. Modern research recognises that project success is a more comprehensive, complex, and frequently subjective construct that is greatly influenced by how well stakeholders are involved throughout the project cycle, in contrast to early project management theory, which measured success narrowly using the so-called iron triangle of time, cost, and quality.

This study synthesises empirical studies that have examined the relationship between stakeholder participation and project success across global, regional (African), and local (Kenyan) contexts.

Objectives of the Review

- To examine global empirical study on the relationship between stakeholder participation and project success.
- To examine regional (African) empirical study on the relationship between stakeholder participation and project success.
- To examine local (Kenyan) empirical study on the relationship between stakeholder participation and project success.
- To identify convergences, divergences, and conceptual gaps in the reviewed literature that can inform further research.

Conceptual Review

Stakeholder Participation (Independent Variable)

Stakeholder participation is the engagement of people, groups, or organisations that have an interest in a project. It includes identifying who the stakeholders are, consulting them, involving them in planning and decision-making, engaging them during project implementation, and allowing them to take part in monitoring and evaluating the project.

It also involves maintaining good communication and giving stakeholders opportunities to provide feedback. When stakeholders actively participate, projects are more likely to gain support, use resources effectively, reduce conflicts, create a sense of ownership, and achieve better results.

Project Success (Dependent Variable)

Project success refers to how well a project achieves its goals and delivers the expected results. It is not only measured by whether the project is completed on time, within budget, and meets quality standards, but also by whether it satisfies stakeholders, achieves its objectives, benefits the organisation or community, and continues to have a positive impact after it is completed. Common indicators of project success include timely completion, cost efficiency, meeting project scope and quality requirements, stakeholder satisfaction, and the long-term sustainability of project outcomes.

Global Studies

Wu, Yan, Pan and Wu (2023) - China

Wu, Yan, Pan, and Wu (2023) looked at how stakeholder participation affects the connection between sustainable project management and sustainable project success in China's construction sector. Stakeholder theory and the Resource-Based View served as the study's guiding principles. It used structured questionnaires to gather data from 365 construction project experts using a quantitative cross-sectional survey approach. To investigate the suggested links, the researchers used structural equation modelling (SEM) to assess the data.

The results demonstrated that stakeholder participation and sustainable project management both significantly improved the effectiveness of sustainable projects. Stakeholder involvement did not, however, considerably mitigate the link between project success and sustainable project management.

The study came to the conclusion that as stakeholder participation directly affects project performance, it is crucial to attaining effective project outcomes. In order to increase overall project performance, the authors advised construction companies to enhance stakeholder involvement by incorporating important stakeholders at every stage of the project lifecycle and putting sustainable project management techniques into practice.

Nguyen, Mohamed and Mostafa (2021) - International

Nguyen, Mohamed, and Mostafa (2021) investigated the connection between project performance and stakeholder participation in both complex and non-complex projects in various nations. Based on a thorough analysis of prior research, the study created a conceptual framework and found 22 quantitative indicators that clarify how stakeholder participation affects project performance. Data was gathered from 144 project managers using structured questionnaires and a quantitative survey approach. Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) and Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) were used to examine the data.

The results showed that in both complex and non-complex projects, stakeholder participation significantly improved the qualitative elements of project performance, such as stakeholder satisfaction and the accomplishment of project objectives. However, higher stakeholder participation was linked to worse schedule performance in complicated projects, indicating that higher stakeholder involvement may cause delays because of more discussions and decision-making procedures.

The study came to the conclusion that the degree of project complexity determines how stakeholder participation affects project performance. To enhance project success and minimise potential delays, it was advised that project managers create stakeholder interaction techniques that are suitable for the complexity of their projects.

De Oliveira and Rabechini Jr. (2019) - Brazil

De Oliveira and Rabechini Jr. (2019) evaluated the impact of stakeholder management on trust among project stakeholders and how this trust affects project performance in Brazil. 130 project managers from both domestic and international businesses in a variety of industries provided data for the study, which used a quantitative research approach. Partial Least Squares Path Modelling (PLS-PM) was used to examine the data.

The results demonstrated that developing trust among project stakeholders was significantly improved by good stakeholder management. The study also discovered that increased levels of trust enhanced stakeholder commitment, cooperation, and communication, all of which improved project success.

The researchers came to the conclusion that building trust, which is crucial for attaining good project outcomes, requires effective stakeholder management. To improve project performance and raise the chances of project success, they advised project managers to concentrate on developing solid and reliable relationships with stakeholders from the start of a project.

Waseem, Saeed and Iqbal (2024) - Pakistan

Waseem, Saeed, and Iqbal (2024) investigated the impact of stakeholder participation on project performance in Pakistan's IT industry, concentrating on the mediating functions of project innovation and communication during a time of political unrest. Using a quantitative cross-sectional survey approach, the study gathered information from 205 IT professionals employed in Pakistan's IT sector. To ascertain the direct and indirect correlations between the research variables, the data were investigated using path analysis in SPSS.

Stakeholder participation significantly improved project performance, according to the data. Stakeholder involvement boosted communication and innovation, which in turn improved project performance, according to the study, which also revealed that successful project communication and innovation amplified this link by functioning as mediating variables.

The researchers came to the conclusion that, especially in unpredictable and unstable circumstances, stakeholder participation is a critical factor in project success. To boost project performance and raise the possibility of successful project results, they advised project managers to encourage active stakeholder engagement while fortifying communication channels and fostering creativity.

Regional (African) Studies

Retta (2021) - Ethiopia

Retta (2021) examined how the German Society for International Cooperation (GIZ) Quality Enhancement Programme (GIZ-QEP) projects in Ethiopia performed in relation to stakeholder management methods, such as stakeholder identification, involvement, communication, and monitoring. A stratified random sample of 122 respondents, comprising both internal and external project stakeholders, was chosen for the study, which focused on 152 stakeholders from twelve GIZ-QEP projects. A pilot-tested questionnaire was used to gather data for the descriptive study approach. To provide descriptive and inferential statistics, the data were analysed using SPSS.

The results demonstrated a strong positive correlation between stakeholder identification, stakeholder engagement, and project success, suggesting that early stakeholder identification and active involvement throughout the project lifecycle improve project performance.

The study came to the conclusion that for donor-funded development initiatives to be implemented successfully, stakeholders must be effectively identified and actively involved. To enhance overall project performance, it was advised that development agencies create formal stakeholder engagement procedures at the outset of project planning and keep stakeholders involved throughout project execution.

Bikadho (2025) - Uganda

Bikadho (2025) looked studied how stakeholder engagement affected the Youth Livelihood Programme (YLP) in Uganda, concentrating on stakeholder involvement in the program's planning, budgeting, and implementation phases. In order to gather opinions from program administrators and grassroots stakeholders, the study used a mixed-methods research methodology that included quantitative and qualitative techniques. Multiple regression analysis and descriptive statistics were used in the SPSS analysis of the gathered data. The chosen factors were helpful in describing program success, as evidenced by the regression model's statistical significance ($F = 21.823$, $p = 0.000$).

The results demonstrated that program performance was positively but statistically insignificantly impacted by stakeholder engagement during the planning and budgeting phases. On the other hand, program outcomes were significantly improved by active stakeholder involvement during the implementation stage.

The study came to the conclusion that while stakeholder participation in planning and budgeting has to be improved, meaningful involvement throughout project execution is crucial for improving program

effectiveness and guaranteeing the long-term sustainability of project benefits. In order to increase the efficacy and durability of development initiatives, the researcher suggested that government organisations bolster participatory mechanisms throughout the project lifetime, especially by promoting more community engagement throughout implementation.

Sulemana et al. (2018) - Ghana

In the Savelugu Nanton Municipal Assembly in Ghana, Sulemana et al. (2018) examined the function of stakeholder involvement in the monitoring and assessment of district assembly development initiatives. Targeting a population of 196 respondents, including 70 employees of the Municipal Planning and Coordinating Unit (MPCU) and 126 members of the community, the study used a single case study research design. Structured questionnaires and in-depth interviews were used to gather data, which was then evaluated using both descriptive statistics and qualitative techniques.

The results showed that while stakeholder involvement in monitoring and evaluation was low among community members and stakeholders at the zonal council level, it was high among district assembly members and MPCU employees. This suggested that monitoring and assessing development programs involved little participation from local stakeholders.

The study came to the conclusion that project sustainability, accountability, and openness are weakened by insufficient community-level stakeholder engagement. In order to improve project performance and guarantee the long-term sustainability of development projects, it was suggested that municipal assemblies increase community engagement by actively integrating local stakeholders in monitoring and evaluation activities throughout the project lifetime.

Irechukwu (2023) - Rwanda

Irechukwu (2023) examined the impact of stakeholder participation in project monitoring and evaluation on the effectiveness of eye healthcare initiatives carried out in Rwanda by the OneSight EssilorLuxottica Foundation. Purposive and stratified sampling were used to pick a sample of 295 respondents, including foundation employees, Ministry of Health employees, project beneficiaries, and employees of eye health hospitals and health centers. The study used both descriptive and correlational research techniques. Secondary reports and closed-ended, five-point Likert-scale questionnaires were used to gather the data, which were then analysed using a regression model in SPSS version 22.0.

The results showed a statistically significant positive correlation ($\text{Beta} = 0.755$, $p < 0.001$) between the performance of eye healthcare projects and stakeholder participation in monitoring and assessment.

The study indicated that the effectiveness and resilience of healthcare initiatives are significantly improved by inclusive stakeholder participation in monitoring and evaluation procedures, and it suggested ongoing investment in adaptive management techniques that take stakeholder input into account.

Local (Kenyan) Studies

Mushori (2020) - Kenya Urban Roads Authority

Mushori (2020) investigated how stakeholder involvement in project execution affected the Kenya Urban Roads Authority's (KURA) urban road transport infrastructure projects' completion. The Yamane method was used to choose a sample of 310 respondents from the 1,593 participants in the survey, which included KURA officials, project-affected individuals, and service providers. This resulted in 214 useable replies, or a 69 percent response rate. The study used a descriptive research survey methodology that collected both quantitative and qualitative data. Correlation and regression analysis were used for analysis.

Stakeholder participation accounted for 63.4 percent of the variation in project completion, and the results demonstrated a strong, positive, and statistically significant relationship between stakeholder participation and the completion of urban road projects ($r = 0.796$, $R\text{-squared} = 0.634$, $F(4,209) = 90.503$, $p < 0.000$).

The study recommended that government agencies work closely with stakeholders on issues like service line relocation and land acquisition to prevent delays, concluding that active stakeholder participation throughout the project lifecycle is essential for the timely completion of road infrastructure projects.

Nginya and Mutuku (2024) - Nairobi City County

In Nairobi City County, Kenya, Nginya and Mutuku (2024) investigated the impact of stakeholder management, which includes stakeholder identification, involvement, communication, and monitoring, on the effectiveness of health care programs funded by non-governmental organisations (NGOs). Using a descriptive research approach, the study focused on 47 NGO-supported healthcare programs and polled 94 respondents who were program officers and project managers. Multiple regression analysis and other descriptive and inferential statistics were used to examine the data, which were gathered via structured questionnaires.

Stakeholder participation showed up as the strongest and most significant predictor of project performance ($B = 1.288$, $p = 0.000$), followed by stakeholder monitoring and stakeholder identification; stakeholder communication was not a statistically significant predictor. The regression model was highly significant ($R\text{-squared} = 0.731$, $F = 52.315$, $p = 0.000$).

In order to improve project outcomes, NGOs operating in Nairobi City County should actively encourage stakeholder collaboration, mutual understanding, and capacity building, according to the study's conclusion that stakeholder participation is a critical driver of the performance of NGO-supported healthcare projects.

Mutuku (2023) - Garissa County

Mutuku (2023) looked on how stakeholder involvement affected irrigation project performance in Kenya's Garissa County. The study used a descriptive research approach and targeted 85 respondents, including 10 project managers and 75 project team members, who were all included in a census survey. It was based on

stakeholder theory, realistic assessment theory, and systems theory. Questionnaires were used to gather data, and multiple regression analysis was used to determine how the independent and dependent variables were related.

The results showed that the success of irrigation projects was positively and significantly impacted by stakeholder analysis, engagement, motivation, and monitoring and assessment.

The study recommended that irrigation project managers keep a clear, regularly updated stakeholder map to direct engagement and communication. It concluded that systematic stakeholder analysis helps organisations obtain support and resources, increase project visibility, and prevent costly roadblocks later in the project cycle.

Amuni, Karimi and Patrick (2025) - Kisumu County

Amuni, Karimi, and Patrick (2025) investigated how donor-funded programs operating in the informal settlements of Kisumu Central Sub-County, Kenya, performed in relation to stakeholder participation in monitoring and evaluation. The study used a Convergent Parallel research design, guided by Stakeholder Engagement Theory, and selected a sample of 364 respondents from 27 donor-funded projects in the Obunga and Nyalenda informal settlements using stratified random sampling for community members and purposive sampling for project staff. This sample was calculated using Yamane's sampling formula. In addition to inferential methods, descriptive statistics such as means and standard deviations were used to evaluate the data.

The results showed that while stakeholder perspectives were not always carefully incorporated into project programming (mean = 2.06), there were frequent opportunities for stakeholder interaction within the projects (mean = 4.05) and that stakeholders contributed significantly to project development (mean = 3.79).

The study found that donor-funded projects performed better when stakeholders were included in monitoring and assessment. It also advised project managers to improve methods for integrating community viewpoints in order to increase project ownership and sustainability.

Summary and Research Gaps

Stakeholder participation, whether operationalised as identification, planning involvement, implementation engagement, communication, or monitoring and evaluation, is positively and, in most cases, significantly associated with project success. This pattern is consistent across the twelve reviewed studies from global, regional, and local contexts. This pattern was consistent across a wide range of industries, including community development, highways, irrigation, construction, information technology, and health, as well as a variety of research methodologies, such as structural equation modelling and descriptive surveys.

However, the examined research also highlight significant differences. Certain aspects of stakeholder participation, like communication in the Nairobi NGO healthcare study and planning/budgeting participation in the Uganda Youth Livelihood Programme study, were not always statistically significant predictors of project success, indicating that different types of participation have varying effects on project outcomes. Stakeholder engagement is frequently lower at the grassroots or community level than at the management or technical levels, according to various African studies (Kisumu, Ghana), suggesting a continuous implementation gap between policy goals and practice.

- Most reviewed studies are based on cross-sectional survey designs, limiting the ability to establish causal link between stakeholder participation and project success over time.
- There is comparatively limited local (Kenyan) empirical evidence explicitly linking stakeholder participation to project success outside the roads, health, and irrigation sectors.
- Few studies have used cross-sectional or mixed-methods approaches which that could better capture how the strength of the stakeholder participation-project success relationship changes across the project lifecycle.

These gaps indicate that more research is required to fully understand how various aspects of stakeholder engagement affect project effectiveness in certain sectors and contexts, especially at the local level and utilizing longitudinal or mixed-methods approaches.

Conclusion

Stakeholder participation is a reliable and consistent indicator of project success, whether at global, regional or local level. Future research should draw on cross-sectional and mixed-methods approaches, and explore more closely how this participation is experienced on the ground, in order to better inform practice and policy.

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